

No Stage Fright

Previous prime ministers gave legitimacy to their posts by seeking election to the Lok Sabha



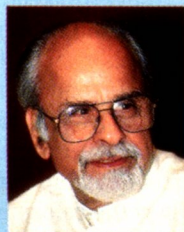
INDIRA GANDHI

She was the I&B minister and a Rajya Sabha member when Shastri's death in 1966 in Tashkent propelled her to prime ministership. Won Lok Sabha election from Rae Bareilly in 1967.



P.V. NARASIMHA RAO

Had retired when Indian politics was thrown topsy turvy after Rajiv Gandhi's assassination. After becoming PM, he fought the Lok Sabha elections from Nandyal. His victory margin remains a record.



INDER KUMAR GUJRAL

A Rajya Sabha member, the surprise consensus candidate who succeeded Deve Gowda contested for the Lok Sabha from Jalandhar. Even the opposition Akali Dal supported this Punjab *da Puttar*.

in the classical sense. When she inherited the party in 1998, the strength of the Congress in the Lok Sabha was 141, with a vote share of 25.82 per cent; and it had seven chief ministers. In the first General Election held under her stewardship the next year, the tally went down to 114, though the party, in a desperate attempt to preserve the mystique of the dynasty in spite of the humiliation, took comfort in the fact that its vote share had gone up by nearly 3 per cent. She may have regained power in 2004, but it was not an absolute victory; it was more of an absolute defeat of the NDA. Today, she may have more chief ministers but the party that ruled all the big states once is now confined to a few tiny states and Union Territories. She

(FROM LEFT) MANMOHAN, SONIA, LALLI, PAWAR AND PASWAN



HEMANT CHAWLA

SONIA'S TASK IS BIGGER THAN merely marketing Manmohan. This is her last chance to restore the original shine of the Dynasty.

Protocol is never broken. Yet she will not let him contest a Lok Sabha election. She will let him take the flak for bringing in tainted ministers into his Cabinet. Then again, you can breach protocols without breaking them. And the 10 Janpath-Race Course Road protocol is one that Sonia does not want to break right now.

More of this Sonia-Manmohan dynamics is what the party is offering to the public. It, however, is not a permanent solution but merely a stopgap arrangement until Rahul is ready. A post on Orkut, a social networking site, says, "The Congress has the most inclusive campaign. An old man who is from a minority, a woman and a young man." And their destinies as the product, the marketer and the next big thing are linked. As the Delphic diva of 10 Janpath and the maximum leader of India's GOP, Sonia has a lot to prove. She has been the Great Helmswoman of the party for more than a decade, but she is not yet a 'Mrs G'

has lost all the biggies except Andhra Pradesh and Rajasthan. In Maharashtra, it is in partnership with the NCP. So Sonia herself has not been a bestseller as a campaigner or a deliverer. Now she has failed to keep the UPA intact as well. She is left with just three partners—DMK, JMM and NCP, whose loyalty is anyway conditioned by its leader's prime ministerial ambition. Sonia's task is bigger than marketing Manmohan. It is her last chance to restore the original shine of the Dynasty. She has a name to live up to. She has to prove that she can win an election—and win like a Gandhi. Ultimately, Manmohan can only be a collateral beneficiary—or damage.

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